

E

O

U

A

I

FIVE LETTERS

WRITINGS IN THE BRITISH MUSEUM



The British Museum houses more than 3,424 pieces with some form of writing; they are located in 49 rooms and 618 cases. The pieces come from more than 62 countries and span more than 5,300 years. It would take someone around 700 hours to catalogue them all. I am that nutcase and these are some of my wonderful findings.

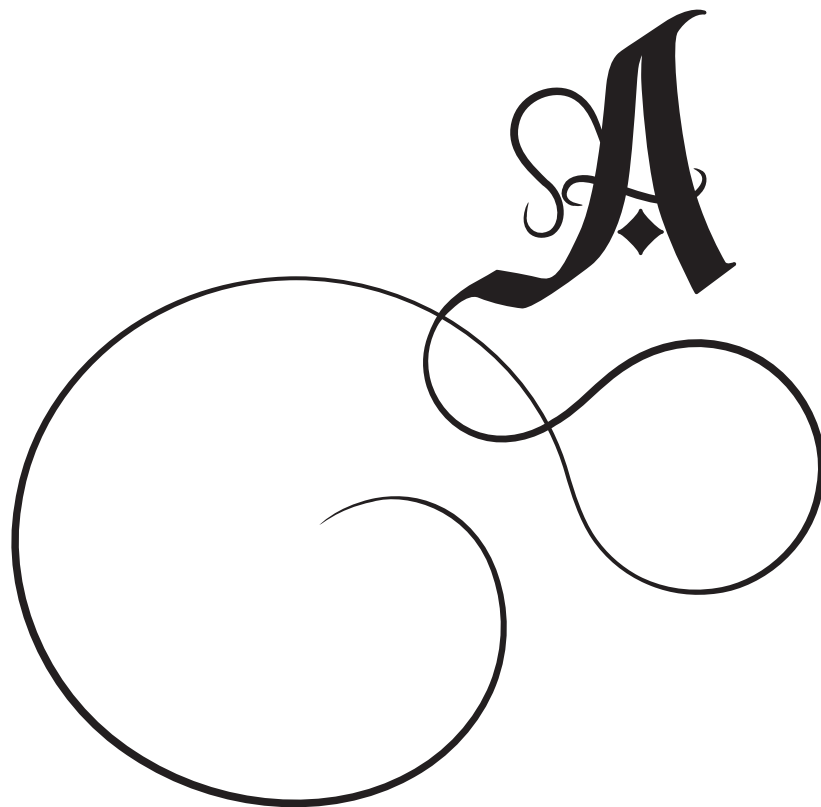


A

The *A* is the first letter of the English, Roman and Phoenician alphabets. In ancient times it was known as *aleph* which meant 'ox' and it is generally accepted that its ancient form evolved from the pictogram of the animal's head; originally, it was a soft consonant instead of a vowel and its sound resembled the break between oh's in *oh-ob*. When it was adopted by the Greeks, it was also slightly altered, assigned to a true vowel sound and named *alpha*. The Greek Ionic variant was eventually adopted by the Etruscans and Romans, where it reached its most refined state.

This particular *A* was taken from *The Triumphal Arch*, one of the largest prints ever produced. Commissioned by the Holy Roman Emperor Maximilian I, designed by the artist Albrecht Dürer in 1515 and cut by Hieronymus Andreae of Nuremberg between 1515 and 1517. It was modelled after the triumphal arches of ancient Rome. The text in the print tells the life of the Emperor and includes his family tree, along with certain scenes from his life. Located in Room 12 of the British Museum. (Catalogue Number: PD E.5-1)

This letter comes from my favourite piece in all of the Museum. Sadly it is a bit forgotten, hidden close to the Museum's Gallery Café on the first floor.



E

The fifth character in the English and Roman alphabets, the *E* is the most employed letter in the English language (as well as most languages using the Roman alphabet). It is thought by some scholars to have derived from an Egyptian hieroglyph of a man with raised arms, while others state that it originally evolved from the pictogram for 'window'. No matter its origin, during the next 700 years, the shape of the letter evolved into more abstract forms and by the time of the Phoenicians, it looked a little like our modern letter. This particular letter was named *epsilon* by the Greeks, and in turn, was adopted by the Etruscans and then the Romans around 600 BC, but was used pointing either left or right. By the third century it was agreed that it should point right.

Taken from the wall of the temple of Athena in Pirene (Greece). In the inscription, King Alexander the Great dedicates the temple to Athena Polias. There is also a treaty between the King and the City of Pirene, in which the city is allowed not to pay taxes. Made in 334 BC, the inscription records the visit of the King to the city and a donation to the temple, which was designed by Pythios (one of the architects of the Mausoleum at Halikarnassos). British Museum Room 78. (Catalogue Number: 1870.3-20.88)

The best examples of writing in the British Museum come from ancient Greece and Rome, with numerous pieces spread over many rooms and floors.

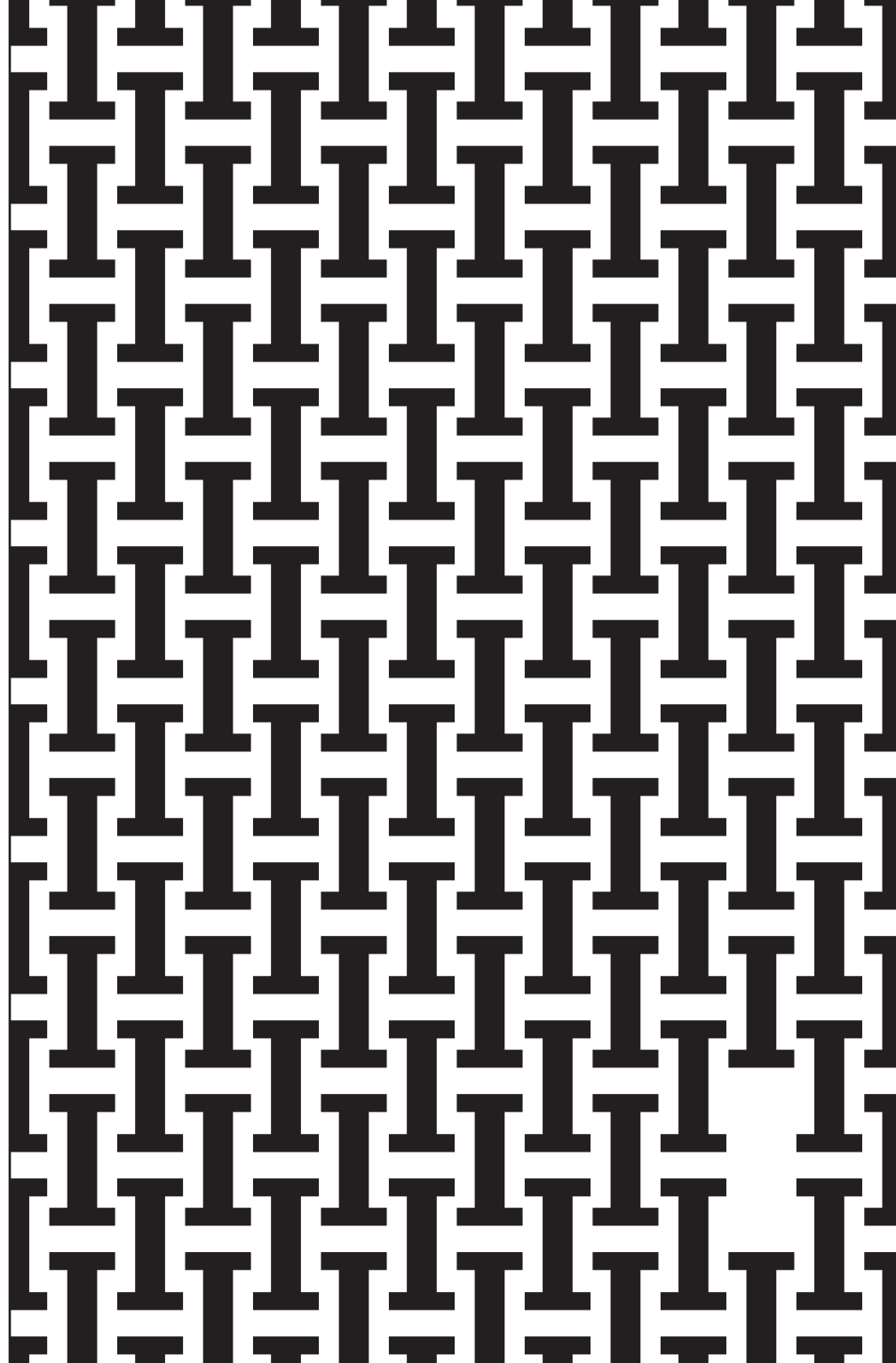


I

The *I* is the ninth letter in the English and Roman alphabets and descended from the Semitic *yod* (a consonant) through the Greek *iota* (a vowel). It is thought by most to have evolved from a pictograph of a hand. Up until the Late Greek period, it used to look like our modern day Z, but it was straightened to the shape we all know and recognize. During Roman times, it was used both as a vowel and as a consonant, eventually giving birth to *I* and *J* in our modern alphabets. The addition of the dot dates from the eleventh century and it's the result of scribes searching for easier recognition within long texts. The stroke of the *I* commonly establishes the height of the rest of the letters, as well as the thickness of the vertical strokes. During the Renaissance, it was established to have a ratio of 9:1 or 10:1, but that has changed in modern times as more and more typefaces are designed.

This particular *I* was copied from a panel with scenes from the *Aeneid*. Painted in Limoges, France by Jean II Penicard between 1540 and 1550. The frame, which contains the inscriptions in Latin, was added later. The texts, which explain the scenes depicted, naming people and places, were copied from engravings by Marcantonio. Located in Room 45 in the Museum. (Catalogue Number: WB 21)

I discovered this *I* in the last room I visited and catalogued. If the Museum is understaffed, it is very likely that the room will be closed.



O

The fifteenth letter of the English and fourteenth of the Roman alphabet. Most scholars believe the *O* evolved from the Semitic letter *ayin*, meaning 'eye', but some think it came from the sign for 'sun'. In Greek times it was called *omicron* and although it gave birth to *omega* to differentiate long and short *O* sounds, the Etruscans adopted the Greek alphabet before its invention, so it passed on to the Romans as the sign for short and long sounds. It has remained virtually unchanged throughout history, but looked more like a square between 1150 and 1500 under the influence of the black letter script. It presents the curved strokes of the typeface and, in theory, all letters can be designed starting from *I* and *O*.

Drawn from a Russian porcelain plate, which commemorates Lenin's plan for the electrification of Russia. Adopted in 1920, it was the first Soviet plan for national economic recovery and development. During the course of 15 years, 30 power plants (10 of them hydroelectric) were to be built. It reads: *Eighth All Union Congress of Soviets accepts electrification plan, December 1920*. Located in Room 48. (Catalogue Number: P&E 2006.4-5.5)

Room 48 is one of the best lit rooms in the Museum and it is always a pleasant room to visit, although a bit small.

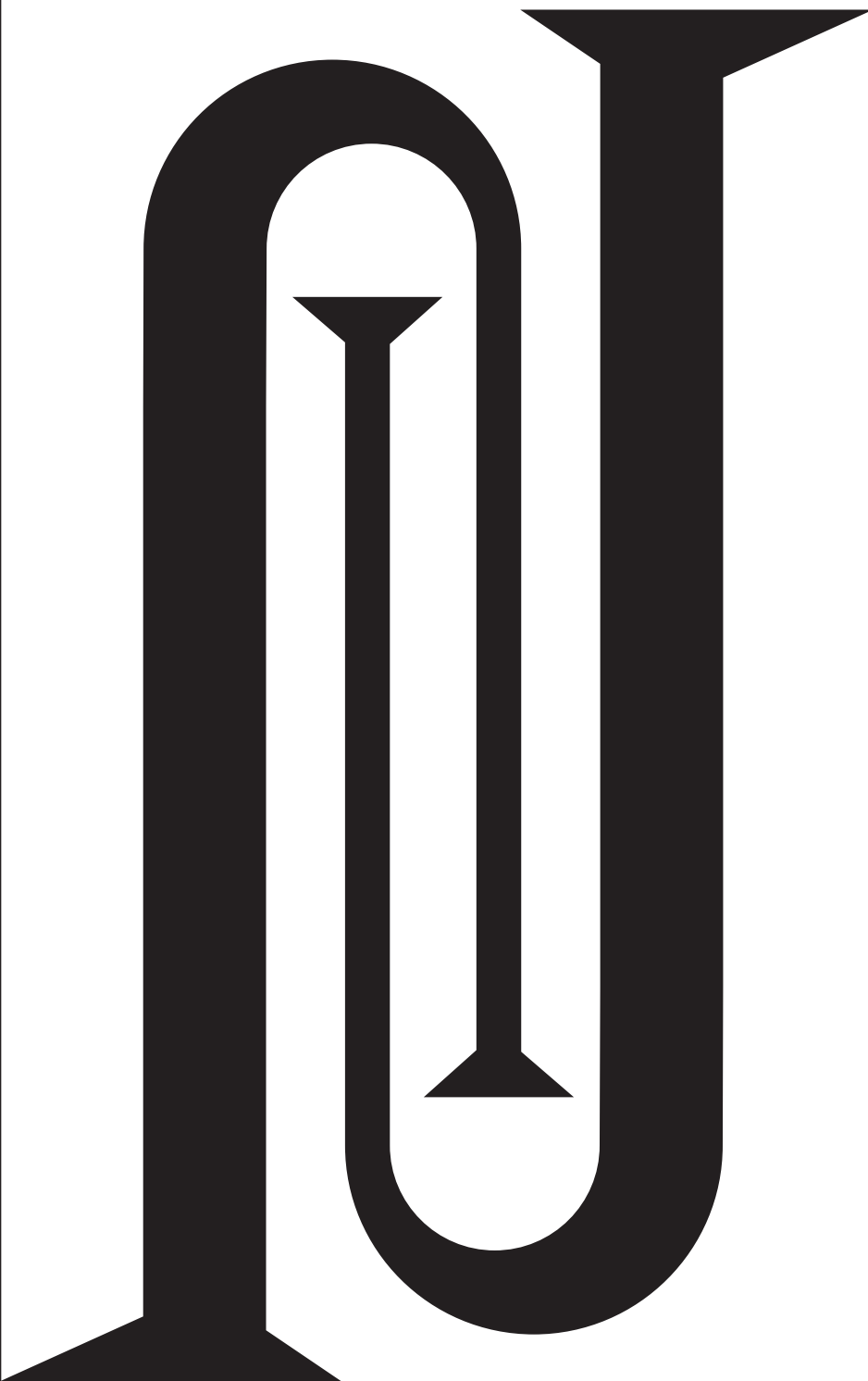


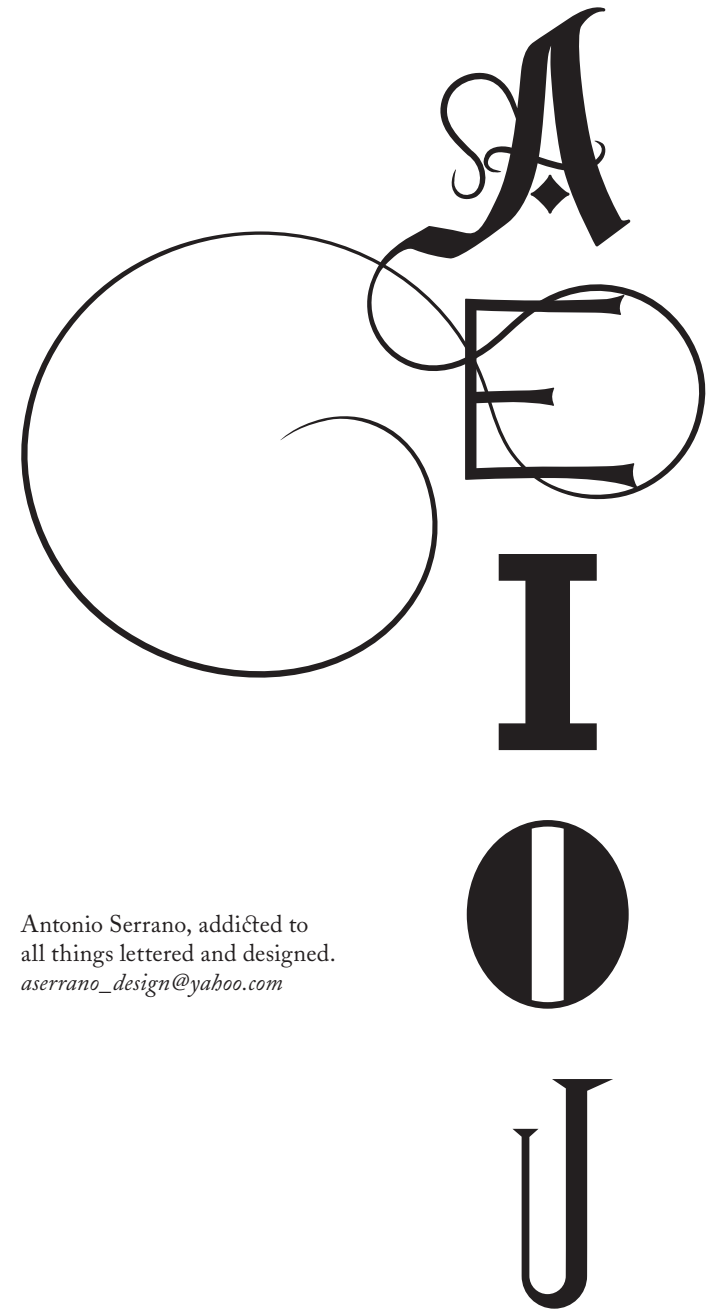
U

The twenty-first letter of the English alphabet, the *U* had no presence in Roman times, its sound being represented by the letter *V*; it was developed during the Renaissance to differentiate these two sounds. Between the third and eighth centuries, a form of *U* was used along with *V* to represent both sounds, its use depending on lower- or upper-case texts (*V* preferred for capitals). During the fifteenth century, its use was realted to the location of the letter within a word, using *V* at the beginning and *U* wherever else *U* or *V* appeared. It was not until the 1700's that the current convention of *U* for *U* and *V* for *V* was established and subsequently accepted. Its modern day birth is evident in printer's cases: while all upper-case letters are arranged alphabetically, *U* and *J* are located at the end.

Taken from the word *PURCHASED* in a bronze cash register lent by Ian Omerond, NCR. Manufactured by Tiffany & Co, New York in 1901, it rests in Room 68 (The Money Gallery). (No Catalogue Number)

The letters in this cash register caught my eye when I first entered the room and because of this I decided to include it in my catalogue. It is the only 'themed' Gallery I mapped.





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